

Lawrence McEnerney’s “Valuable Writing” Theory: The Reader-Value Model

Introduction

Lawrence McEnerney occupies a singular position in the landscape of writing instruction. For over four decades, he served at the University of Chicago, first as a graduate student and instructor beginning in 1978, then as Director of the University Writing Program from 1992 until his retirement. He was not a composition theorist in the conventional academic sense; he published no monographs, advanced no formal theoretical apparatus, and situated himself outside the disciplinary conversations of rhetoric and composition studies. Yet his influence on how writers—particularly graduate students and early-career academics—understand the purpose and craft of writing has been enormous. His 2014 lecture “The Craft of Writing Effectively,” delivered as part of the University of Chicago Leadership Lab series, has accumulated over eight million views on YouTube, making it arguably the most widely consumed single statement on academic writing pedagogy in history. His framework, which this report terms the Reader-Value Model, represents a practitioner’s synthesis of insights drawn from genre theory, social-epistemic rhetoric, and post-process thought, distilled into actionable advice that has reshaped how a generation of scholars thinks about the act of writing.

Background: The Practitioner and His Lineage

McEnerney’s intellectual formation was shaped decisively by Joseph M. Williams, the linguist and rhetorician who co-founded the University of Chicago’s celebrated “Little Red Schoolhouse” course with Gregory G. Colomb. Williams, whose *Style: Lessons in Clarity and Grace* remains one of the most influential writing textbooks in the English language, served on McEnerney’s doctoral preliminary examination and became his mentor. Under Williams’s influence, McEnerney pivoted from literary scholarship to writing instruction, joining the original cohort of twelve instructors who taught the Little Red Schoolhouse—a ten-week intensive course in academic and professional

writing that became a signature offering of the University of Chicago (University of Chicago News, 2023).

As Director of the Writing Program, McEnerney oversaw initiatives serving more than two thousand community members annually, encompassing first-year humanities courses, graduate writing workshops, and professional tutoring programs. He and his wife, Cathe, also served as resident deans at the Renee Granville-Grossman Residential Commons East beginning in 2009, embedding him further in the fabric of the university's intellectual life. His approach to writing pedagogy was always practical rather than theoretical. He did not write for *College Composition and Communication* or engage in the methodological debates that animated the field of rhetoric and composition. Instead, he taught, lectured, consulted, and refined a set of principles through decades of direct engagement with student writing across every discipline the University of Chicago housed. This practitioner orientation is essential to understanding both the power and the limitations of his framework.

The Core Framework: From Clarity to Value

The fundamental claim of McEnerney's Reader-Value Model is deceptively simple: writing that is clear, organized, and grammatically correct may still fail entirely if it is not *valuable* to its readers. This is the central provocation of his work, and it runs directly counter to the assumptions embedded in most writing instruction from kindergarten through graduate school. The conventional hierarchy of writing virtues—clarity, organization, coherence, correctness—treats these qualities as both necessary and sufficient conditions for effective writing. McEnerney insists that they are necessary but radically insufficient. As he states in his UChicago lecture, "If it's clear and organized and it doesn't have any value, that's bad writing." Or, more bluntly: "Explaining is revealing to the world what is inside your head. No one cares what is inside of your head."

This claim represents a Copernican shift in the orientation of writing instruction. Traditional pedagogy positions the writer at the center of the enterprise: the writer has ideas, knowledge, or arguments, and the task of writing is to communicate these as clearly as possible. McEnerney repositions the reader at the center. The question is not "Have I communicated my ideas clearly?" but rather "Have I created something my readers find valuable?" This distinction is not merely semantic. It redefines the entire purpose of revision, the criteria for evaluating a draft, and the relationship between writer and audience.

The implications cascade outward. If value is the primary criterion, then the writer's first task is not to organize material or polish prose but to understand what the target audience considers valuable in the first place. Knowledge alone does not create good writing, because knowledge is not inherently valuable—it becomes valuable only when a specific community of readers recognizes it

as addressing a problem, tension, or instability that they care about. A writer may possess genuine insight, but if that insight does not engage the concerns of the discourse community to which the writing is addressed, it will be ignored, rejected, or simply unread.

The Reader-Value Model in Detail

Value as Community-Defined

The most theoretically consequential element of McEnerney's framework is his insistence that value is not an intrinsic property of knowledge or text but is instead defined by the discourse community in which the writing circulates. Each academic field, each professional domain, and each publishing venue constitutes a community with its own implicit and explicit standards for what counts as valuable contribution. These standards are not universal; they shift across disciplines, evolve over time, and are enforced by specific individuals who hold power within the community—editors, peer reviewers, funding agencies, senior scholars, and institutional gatekeepers.

McEnerney is unusually direct about the role of power in this process. Writers, he argues, must identify who holds power in their community and understand what those powerful readers value. This is not cynicism; it is pragmatism. A paper submitted to a journal is evaluated by reviewers whose own intellectual commitments, methodological preferences, and disciplinary allegiances shape their assessment of value. A grant proposal is judged by panelists whose priorities reflect the funding agency's strategic interests. Writing that fails to engage these evaluative frameworks is not merely unsuccessful—it is, in McEnerney's terms, valueless, regardless of its intrinsic quality.

The Knowledge-Value Distinction

Central to the Reader-Value Model is the sharp distinction between knowledge and value. McEnerney observes that scholars routinely conflate these two categories, assuming that the accumulation of new knowledge automatically produces valuable writing. This assumption is false. A researcher may spend years gathering data, conducting experiments, and generating findings, only to produce a paper that no journal will publish—not because the findings are wrong, but because they do not address a question the community cares about. The knowledge is real, but it lacks value because it has not been framed in terms of a problem that matters to readers.

This distinction carries profound consequences for how writers approach their work. The motivation “I want to share what I've learned” is, in McEnerney's analysis, one of the most common and most destructive impulses in academic writing. It positions the writer as a knowledge-transmitter and the reader as a passive recipient. But readers are not passive; they are busy, skeptical,

and self-interested. They read to solve problems they already have, to address tensions they already feel, or to gain advantages they already seek. Writing that begins from the writer's desire to share knowledge rather than from the reader's need for value will almost invariably fail to hold the reader's attention.

Instability, Tension, and Cost Language

McEnerney devotes substantial attention to the specific linguistic mechanisms through which writers signal value to their discourse communities. He identifies a category of language that he variously terms "instability language," "tension language," or "cost/benefit language." These are words and phrases that indicate to readers that something in their existing understanding is unstable, incomplete, or wrong—and that this instability carries consequences. Examples include "however," "but," "although," "inconsistent," "anomaly," "challenge," "problematic," "contrary to," "despite," "overlooked," and "neglected."

These words function as signals to readers that the writer is about to create value by addressing a genuine problem. They introduce what McEnerney calls instability into the reader's understanding of the world. Without such instability, there is no reason for the reader to continue reading, because the existing state of knowledge is perfectly adequate. The presence of instability language in the opening sentences of an academic paper or professional document immediately engages readers by promising that something they thought they understood is, in fact, more complicated, more uncertain, or more consequential than they believed.

McEnerney further distinguishes between two frameworks of instability. The first is "gap language," which identifies a missing piece of knowledge—something the community does not yet know but would benefit from knowing. Gap language is relatively gentle and non-confrontational; it extends existing knowledge without challenging it. The second is "error language," which asserts that the community's existing beliefs are actually wrong in some respect. Error language is more powerful but also more dangerous, requiring considerable diplomatic skill to deploy without alienating the very readers the writer needs to persuade. Successful academic writers learn to calibrate their instability language to the norms and tolerance thresholds of their specific communities.

Beyond instability itself, McEnerney emphasizes the necessity of articulating *cost*—the consequences of leaving the instability unresolved—or *benefit*—the advantages of resolving it. Readers must understand not merely that a problem exists but that the problem matters, that it carries stakes. An instability without cost is a curiosity; an instability with cost is a research problem.

The Critique of Traditional Writing Education

One of McEnerney's most provocative and widely cited arguments concerns the fundamental mismatch between the writing instruction students receive throughout their educational careers and the demands of professional writing. He contends that from kindergarten through undergraduate education, students learn to write for a single type of reader: the teacher. Teachers are, in McEnerney's formulation, "paid to care about you." They read student writing not because it is valuable to them but because evaluating student performance is their professional obligation. The entire apparatus of writing instruction—assignments, rubrics, feedback, grades—operates within this artificial economy of compelled attention.

This arrangement teaches students a set of habits that are not merely unhelpful but actively counterproductive when they enter professional and academic discourse. Students learn to write as a demonstration of competence: "Here is what I have learned; please evaluate whether I have learned it correctly." They learn to open papers with background information and definitions, to organize material in ways that demonstrate thoroughness, and to conclude by restating what they have covered. These habits are perfectly calibrated for writing that will be read by someone obligated to read it. They are catastrophic for writing that must earn its readers' attention.

The transition from student writing to professional writing is therefore not a matter of refinement or polishing. It requires a fundamental reconception of what writing is for. The student writes to display knowledge; the professional writes to change what readers think about the world. The student writes for a captive audience; the professional writes for an audience that has no obligation to read and will stop reading at the first sign that the writing lacks value. McEnerney argues that this transition is one of the most difficult intellectual challenges that graduate students face, and that most writing instruction fails to prepare them for it because it never addresses the question of value at all.

Practical Techniques

McEnerney's framework is distinguished from purely theoretical accounts of writing by its emphasis on specific, actionable techniques that writers can immediately employ.

Identifying Community Values

McEnerney recommends that writers devote sustained attention to learning the implicit value codes of their discourse community. His primary method is systematic reading: he advises writers to spend fifteen minutes each day reading published work in their field, not for content but for

language. Specifically, writers should identify and circle the words and phrases that signal value—the instability language, the cost language, the terms that mark a contribution as significant. Over time, this practice builds an internalized vocabulary of value that the writer can deploy in their own work.

Opening with Instability

McEnerney is emphatic that academic and professional writing should open not with background information, context, or definitions but with instability. The first sentences of a paper should create tension in the reader’s mind by identifying a problem, contradiction, or gap in existing knowledge. This technique directly contradicts the “funnel” or “Martini glass” model taught in most composition courses, which instructs students to begin with broad generalizations and narrow toward a thesis. McEnerney argues that this model is backwards: by the time the reader reaches the thesis, they have already lost interest, because nothing in the opening paragraphs gave them a reason to care.

Using Community-Specific Value Language

Because value is community-defined, the language that signals value varies across disciplines and professional contexts. A word that carries tremendous weight in one field may be meaningless in another. McEnerney instructs writers to study the specific vocabulary of their target venues—the journals they wish to publish in, the agencies they wish to apply to, the audiences they wish to reach—and to incorporate that vocabulary deliberately into their writing. This is not a matter of jargon for its own sake but of demonstrating that the writer understands what the community considers important.

Revision for Value

Perhaps the most consequential practical insight in McEnerney’s framework is his reconception of the revision process. Traditional writing instruction teaches students to revise for clarity, organization, and correctness. McEnerney argues that the primary question during revision should be: “What is valuable here?” A draft may be clear and well-organized but lack value; in that case, no amount of sentence-level revision will improve it. The writer must return to the fundamental question of what problem the writing addresses and whether that problem matters to the intended readers.

Writing Beyond the Academy

In a companion lecture titled “Writing Beyond the Academy,” delivered in January 2015, McEnerney extends his framework to non-academic professional contexts. The core principles remain the same—value supersedes clarity, readers define value, instability creates engagement—but the application shifts in significant ways. McEnerney identifies specific patterns of academic writing that “aggravate” non-academic readers: excessive qualification, abstract language, deferred thesis statements, and a tendency to write as though readers owe the writer their attention.

In professional contexts outside the university, the power dynamics are even more explicit. Writers must provide value immediately or risk losing their readers entirely. McEnerney reframes the relationship between writer and reader in transactional terms: inside academia, the implicit message is “Here is what you believe, and you are wrong”; outside academia, it becomes “Here is what you need, and I can provide it.” The professional writer succeeds not by demonstrating expertise but by identifying what readers need and delivering it efficiently. McEnerney also emphasizes that concision in professional writing is not merely a matter of word count but of processing time—how quickly readers can extract value from the text. Sentence structure, subject placement, and information ordering all contribute to the reader’s processing speed and therefore to the perceived value of the writing.

Intellectual Connections

Although McEnerney does not frame his work in explicitly theoretical terms, the Reader-Value Model draws on and synthesizes several important currents in rhetoric and composition studies. His emphasis on discourse communities as the locus of value echoes the genre theory tradition associated with Carolyn Miller, John Swales, and Charles Bazerman, all of whom argue that texts are shaped by and derive their meaning from the social contexts in which they circulate. His attention to power—specifically, his insistence that writers must identify who holds evaluative authority within their community—resonates with the social-epistemic rhetoric of James Berlin, which foregrounds the ideological and institutional dimensions of writing and knowledge production.

McEnerney’s rejection of writing as the transparent transmission of pre-existing thought aligns with post-process theory, which holds that writing is a situated, contextual activity that cannot be reduced to a generalizable set of procedures. And his practical emphasis on the relationship between writer and reader echoes the audience-awareness tradition that runs from classical rhetoric through Wayne Booth’s *The Rhetoric of Fiction* to contemporary reader-response theory.

The closest published analogue to McEnerney’s framework is Gerald Graff and Cathy Birkenstein’s *They Say / I Say: The Moves That Matter in Academic Writing* (2006), which similarly

emphasizes that academic writing is fundamentally a conversation with an existing discourse community. Graff and Birkenstein provide template structures for entering academic conversations—“they say X, but I say Y”—that parallel McEnerney’s instability framework. However, McEnerney goes further than Graff and Birkenstein in two respects. First, he foregrounds value rather than conversation as the primary criterion: it is not enough to join the conversation; one must say something the community finds valuable. Second, he attends more explicitly to power dynamics, insisting that writers understand not just what the community is discussing but who within the community determines what counts as a legitimate contribution.

McEnerney’s intellectual debt to his mentor Joseph Williams is also evident throughout the Reader-Value Model. Williams’s *Style* teaches writers to construct prose that is clear and direct, emphasizing the reader’s processing needs over the writer’s expressive preferences. McEnerney extends this reader-centered orientation from the sentence level to the level of entire texts and writing projects, asking not just “Is this sentence easy to read?” but “Is this text worth reading?”

Criticisms and Limitations

The Reader-Value Model, for all its practical power, is subject to several important criticisms. The most fundamental is the charge of instrumentalism. By defining good writing exclusively in terms of its value to readers, McEnerney’s framework risks reducing writing to a strategic calculation—a matter of identifying what powerful people want to hear and delivering it to them. This instrumentalist orientation leaves little room for writing that challenges existing community values, disrupts established hierarchies, or introduces genuinely novel frameworks that readers do not yet know they need. The history of intellectual progress is replete with texts that were initially rejected by their discourse communities precisely because they violated prevailing standards of value, only to be recognized as transformative contributions decades later.

A related concern is that the “powerful readers” framework may reinforce existing hierarchies rather than challenge them. By instructing writers to identify and cater to the evaluative preferences of editors, reviewers, and senior scholars, McEnerney’s advice implicitly legitimizes the structures of gatekeeping that determine whose voices are heard within a given community. For writers from marginalized backgrounds, whose perspectives may be structurally devalued by existing discourse communities, the injunction to “write what powerful readers value” may function as a mechanism of exclusion rather than empowerment.

McEnerney’s framework also undervalues the aesthetic and expressive dimensions of writing. Not all writing aims to solve problems or address instabilities. Creative nonfiction, personal essays, lyric essays, and other literary genres derive their value from qualities—beauty, emotional resonance, formal innovation, the articulation of subjective experience—that do not fit comfortably

within the cost-benefit framework of the Reader-Value Model. McEnerney acknowledges this limitation implicitly by restricting his claims to academic and professional writing, but even within those domains, the most memorable and influential writing often succeeds in part because of its aesthetic qualities.

Finally, the model's emphasis on community-specific value language may inadvertently promote a kind of disciplinary insularity. If writers are trained to adopt the value vocabulary of their existing community, they may become less capable of writing across disciplinary boundaries or for general audiences. In an era that increasingly demands interdisciplinary collaboration and public engagement with scholarly research, this limitation is non-trivial.

Influence and Reception

McEnerney's influence has been unusual in both its scale and its mode of dissemination. Unlike most writing pedagogues, whose impact is mediated through published scholarship, McEnerney's ideas have spread primarily through oral instruction and, since the mid-2010s, through the viral circulation of his recorded lectures. The "Craft of Writing Effectively" video has been viewed over eight million times and has generated extensive secondary commentary in the form of blog posts, summaries, notes, and discussion threads across platforms. His ideas have been taken up by graduate writing programs, professional development workshops, and individual writers worldwide, often in contexts far removed from the University of Chicago.

Within the institutional landscape of writing instruction, McEnerney's impact is most visible in the transformation of graduate writing pedagogy. His emphasis on value over correctness, on reader needs over writer intentions, and on the social dimensions of writing has contributed to a broader shift in how graduate programs conceive of writing training. Programs that once focused exclusively on grammar, citation conventions, and disciplinary formatting increasingly incorporate exercises in audience analysis, value identification, and community-specific rhetorical strategy—all hallmarks of McEnerney's approach.

His framework also resonates with and has been amplified by adjacent pedagogical movements. The "Writing in the Disciplines" approach, which emphasizes that writing norms vary across academic fields and that students must learn the conventions of their specific discipline, shares McEnerney's insistence on community-defined standards. The growing emphasis on "knowledge translation" and "research communication" in STEM fields similarly reflects McEnerney's core insight that knowledge must be framed in terms of reader value to achieve impact.

Conclusion

Lawrence McEnerney's Reader-Value Model represents a decisive intervention in writing pedagogy—one that shifts the fundamental question from “Is this writing clear?” to “Is this writing valuable?” By insisting that value is defined by discourse communities rather than by writers, that readers must have a reason to care before they will read, and that traditional writing education systematically fails to prepare students for the demands of professional discourse, McEnerney has articulated a framework that is at once theoretically grounded and immediately practical. His ideas synthesize insights from genre theory, social-epistemic rhetoric, and post-process thought into a coherent practitioner's philosophy, and his viral lectures have disseminated that philosophy to millions of writers who might never encounter the academic scholarship from which it draws. The limitations of his approach—its instrumentalism, its potential to reinforce existing hierarchies, its neglect of aesthetic dimensions—are real but do not diminish the fundamental power of his central insight: that writing which does not create value for its readers, however clear and correct it may be, has failed at its most essential task.

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